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Nirula's	Sagar Ratna	Yo! China	Haldiram's	Bikanervala	MTR	Murugan Idli Shop
75	52	42 stores, 35 carts	16	35 + 88 chat cafes**	3	9 in India
10	24	12	5	13	1	2
150	88	100 PoPs	26	148	NA	15
10	39	15	5	27	4-5	3

* Includes Pizza Hut Delivery; ** Bikanero chat cafes; PoPs: Points of Presence

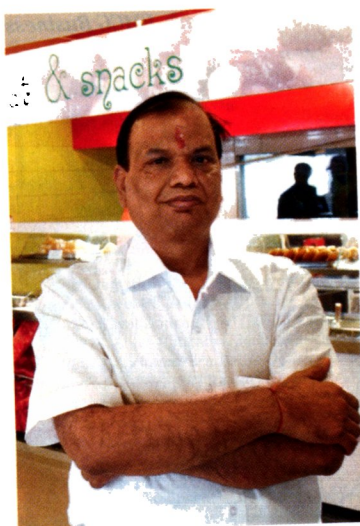
scribed 31 times. In March, Cafe Coffee Day raised over \$200 million (Rs 920 crore) from three private equity funds. "These are very sizeable investments," says Raghav Gupta, president, Technopak Advisors, "and reflect a sense of confidence."

Growth isn't the only change in the food business. The shift from unorganised or street food towards a cleaner, more hygienic environment is one, even as the proliferation of stalls selling steamed corn, doughnuts and even sushi across malls, along with the success of South Indian cuisine in Delhi and butter chicken in the South shows that Indians are willing to experiment. "Even in Chennai, 40 per cent of my customers are north Indians," says S. Manoharan, proprietor, MIS. He plans to have a franchise outlet in Delhi in the next one year.

In the 90s, global fast food firms placed their bets on India, hoping to hook locals on Western food. Yum! entered India with KFC in Bangalore in 1995, but got mired in controversy. Having put that behind, the company worked towards expanding its base

"An Indian is only ultimately satisfied by desi food, no matter how many pizzas or burgers he eats."

SHYAM SUNDER AGGARWAL, MD,
Bikanervala



and today owns over 60 outlets. KFC has also tailored some dishes for Indian tastes. There's chicken tikka masala pizza, zinger burger, chana crunch snacker, veg pulao and makhni curry, and the recently launched nimbu crushers. "One of the biggest questions is whether restaurants can localise as every region of India has a different taste," says B. Narayanaswamy, president, Ipsos Indica Research. Selling ethnic food on a national scale hasn't been easy in a country historically used to a variety of dishes. However, localising is not only about the palate, but also about pricing. "Value is a big point," says Gupta. "Compared to a basic burger, if you get say a thali for Rs 50, people will opt for that." To counter that, Domino's re-launched its 'Pizza Mania' offer, serving pizzas at Rs 35.

Clearly, India is not all about pizza and burgers. Ethnic Quick Service Restaurant (QSR) chains too have a huge following. However, unlike their Western counterparts, home grown chains have largely been restricted to specific regions. Haldiram's, for in-